

IVACS 2024, 16-17 July
University of Cambridge

SHERLOCK HOLMES IN THE COMPUTER



(catherine.wong@sheffield.ac.uk)



University of
Sheffield





TABLE OF CONTENTS



01

**Background:
Why
Detective
Fiction**

02

**Methods &
Findings**

03

Discussion

04

Conclusion

BACKGROUND

- Detective fiction is an intriguing genre as readers are attracted to the story not because of **what** is going to happen but rather, **how** it happens.
- The joy of reading is coming from readers' **expectation** because of their familiarity with the structure of the plot,
- While this expectation turns into **anticipation** through the narrator's apt control of the **pace** of release of information.

DETECTIVE & HIS SIDEKICK

Suspense: the pace of revelation of the truth is mediated by the orders of switching perspectives between characters

Image source: <https://www.netflix.com/hk-en/title/70202589>

LITERATURE REVIEW

- Detective fiction is a literary subgenre which intrigues not only literary scholars but also linguists and scholars of communication studies and narratology.
- Tzvetan Todorov's **structural approaches** to detective fiction (Todorov, 1977) sets the tone of the study and has then influenced many subsequent research on this literary subgenre.

PATTERNS & FORMULA

- Scholars generally agree that the fascination of detective fiction comes from its '**formula**', i.e. its narrative strategies (Dove, 1989; Hühn, 1987; Segal, 2010).
- Hühn gives credits of the uniqueness of detective fiction to its 'classical formula, [which] seems to be unique among narrative genres in that it thematizes narrativity itself as a problem, a procedure, and an achievement' (Hühn, 1987: 451).

THE LOCKED ROOM

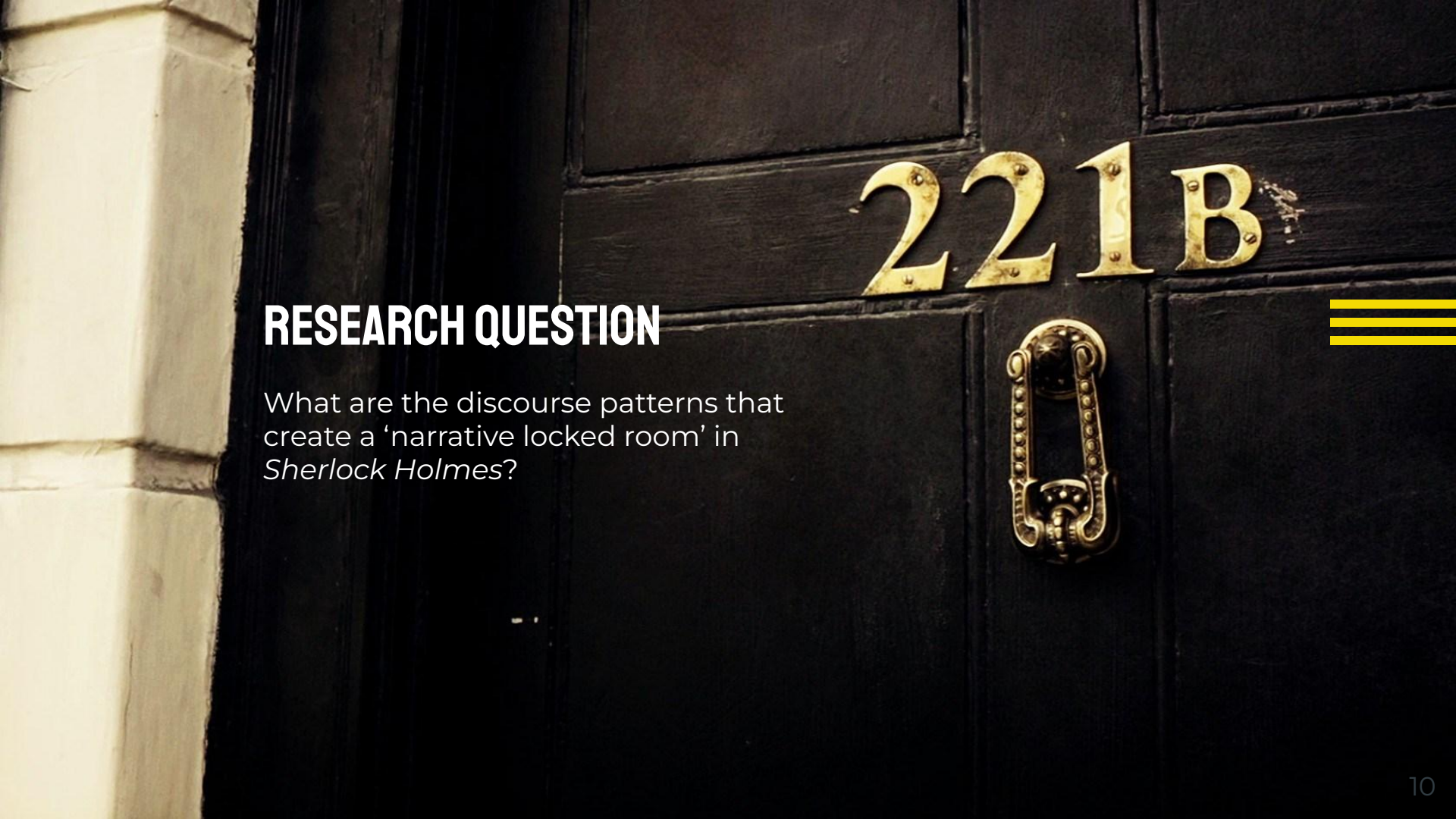
- Detective fiction engages its readers not by providing new and unexpected information but rather, through deploying its readers to play the role of the detective: readers' job is to reconstruct 'a hidden or lost story (that is, the crime)' and 'the process of reconstruction (that is, the detection)'.
- Michael Cook (2011) aptly analogises this story formula as '**the locked room mystery**'.

SUSPENSE

- Suspense is the result of a **discourse structure** in which the narrator's delayed release of information affects the readers' cognitive processing of a story (Hoeken and van Vliet, 2000).
- It is the product of '**postponing the story's outcome**' (Hoeken and van Vliet, 2000: 277) through which pleasure is evoked when readers are led to admire the superiority of intelligence of the detective;
- On the other hand, in a crime fiction, while a crime is always anticipated, readers' enjoyment of the story is coming from the answering of their curiosity and surprise created by the unexpected methods adopted by the 'ingenious' criminal.

NARRATIVE CONFINEMENT

- Psychologists have attempted to unlock this '**narrative enclosure**' and theorise such a story schema as in the correlation between a narrative structure and the emotions it elicits from its readers (such as surprise and suspense) (Brewer & Lichtenstein, 1982).

A close-up, low-angle shot of a dark, paneled wooden door. The door is made of dark wood with visible grain and vertical paneling. Mounted on the door is a brass handle with a decorative, ornate design. Above the handle, the address '221B' is displayed in large, raised brass letters. The letters are slightly weathered and have a warm, golden-brown patina. To the left of the door, a portion of a light-colored stone or concrete wall is visible, showing some texture and a vertical joint. The lighting is dramatic, with strong highlights on the brass elements and deep shadows in the wood panels.

221B

RESEARCH QUESTION

What are the discourse patterns that create a 'narrative locked room' in *Sherlock Holmes*?



METHODOLOGY



62 stories in total
(4 novels + 5 short story collection)

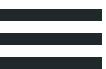
Selected by detective:
Sherlock Holmes

10 short stories
(within 300 TCUs)

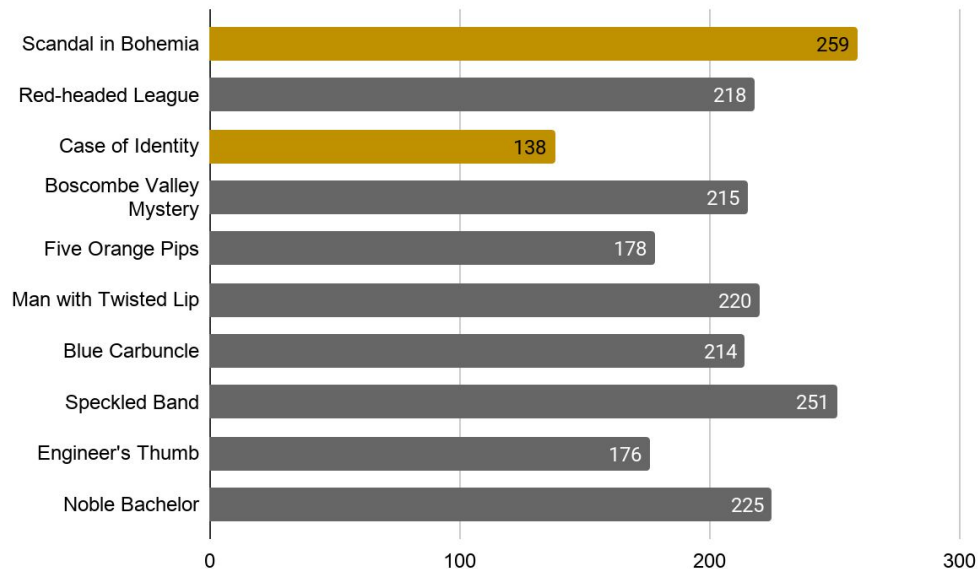
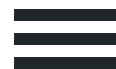
Narrow down by
length: short stories
from *The Adventures*
of *Sherlock Holmes*

Segmentation

Stories are
segmented into turn
construction units
(TCUs)



10 SHORT STORIES IN SHERLOCK HOLMES



Token

85979

Type

7169

TCU

2094

Total number of turn construction unit (TCU) in *Adventures of Sherlock Holmes*

MOST FREQUENTLY USED WORD AFTER 'THE'

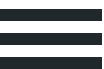
'The' is the most frequently used word in the dataset: 4657 times

FREQUENCY	CLUSTER
66	the door
65	the matter
65	the other
47	the same
46	the room
39	the man
38	the house
36	the case
35	the time
33	the first

WHAT ABOUT 'THE DOOR'?

Locating the position of the cluster in the stories





WHEN 'THE DOOR' APPEARS

HIT FILE: 1 FILE: SH 1.txt



No. of Hits = 9

File Length (in chars) = 46494

HIT FILE: 2 FILE: SH 2.txt



No. of Hits = 10

File Length (in chars) = 49474

HIT FILE: 3 FILE: SH 3.txt



No. of Hits = 5

File Length (in chars) = 37943

HIT FILE: 4 FILE: SH 4.txt



No. of Hits = 3

File Length (in chars) = 51372

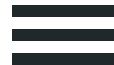
HIT FILE: 5 FILE: SH 5.txt



No. of Hits = 3

File Length (in chars) = 39497

Total number of sentences in *Adventures of Sherlock Holmes*



SH1

39th TCU

SH2

2nd TCU

SH4

130th TCU

SHI



39	A slow and heavy step, which had been heard upon the stairs and in the passage, paused immediately outside the door .
40	Then there was a loud and authoritative tap of obstinacy.
41	"Come in!" said Holmes.

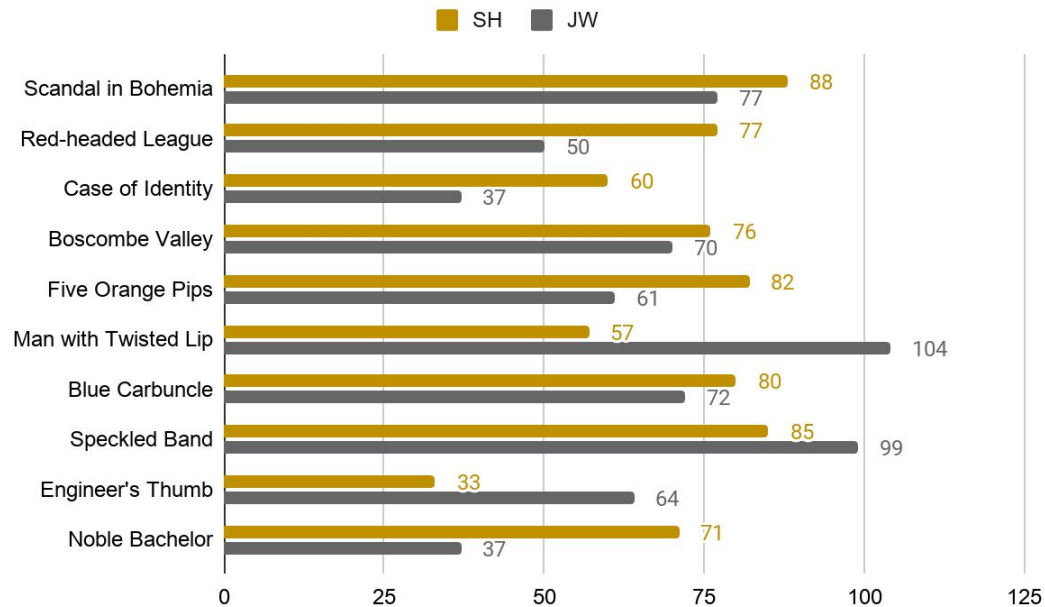
‘A Scandal in Bohemia’

SH 2

1	I had called upon my friend, Mr. Sherlock Holmes, one day in the autumn of last year and found him in deep conversation with a very stout, florid-faced, elderly gentleman with fiery red hair.
2	With an apology for my intrusion, I was about to withdraw when Holmes pulled me abruptly into the room and closed the door behind me.
3	A slow and heavy step, which had been heard upon the stairs and in the passage, paused immediately outside the door .
4	"You could not possibly have come at a better time, my dear Watson," he said cordially.
5	"I was afraid that you were engaged."
6	"So I am. Very much so."

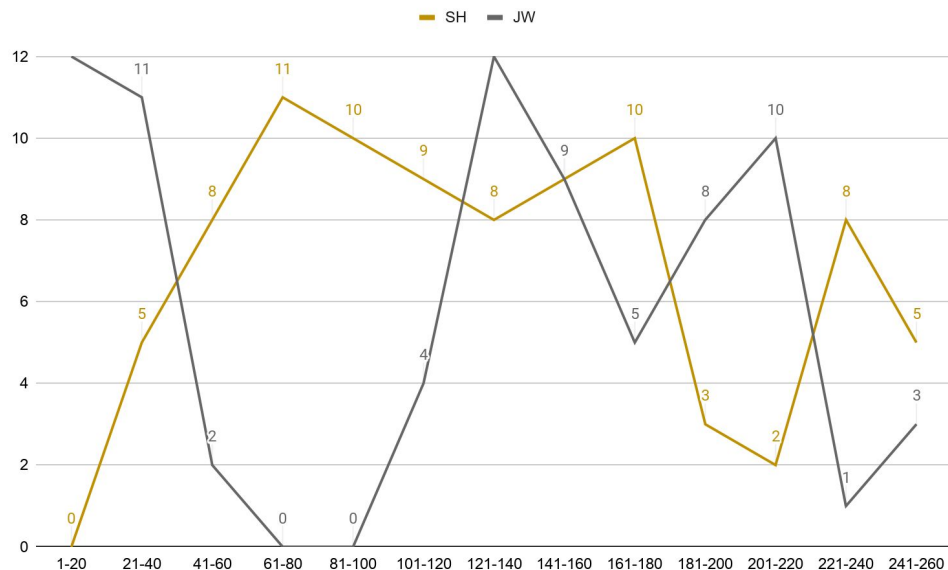
‘The Red-Headed League’

POINT OF VIEW & RED HERRING



The frequency of TCUUs by Sherlock Holmes (**SH**) and Dr. Watson (**JW**) (as both I-narrator and character)

RIVALRY BETWEEN HOLMES AND WATSON'S POV



Holmes

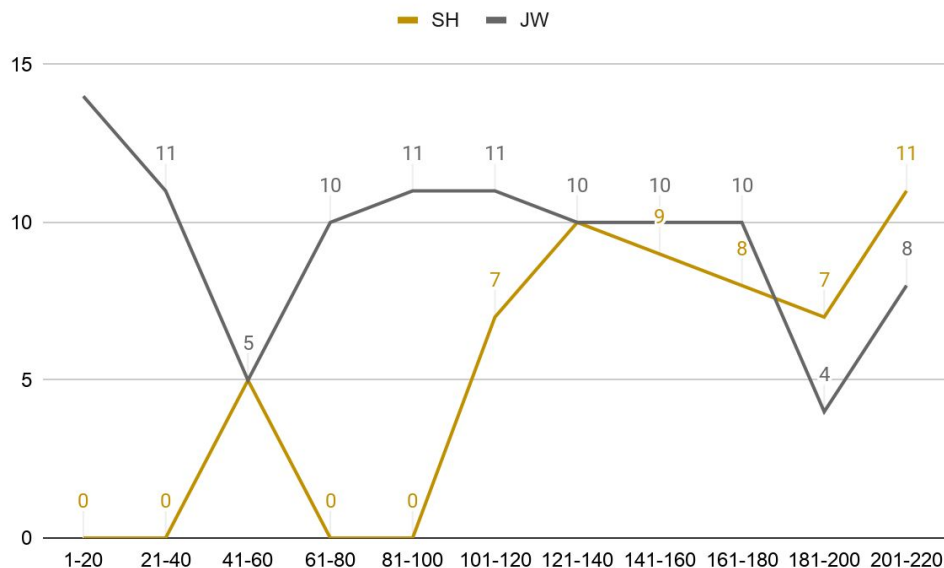
Holmes's POV dominates in the rising action and the resolution of the story

Watson

Watson's POV dominates at the beginning as well as towards the climax of the story

SH vs JW in 'A Scandal in Bohemia'

HOLMES'S NARRATIVE AND THE TRUTH



SH vs JW in 'The Man with the Twisted Lip'

Holmes

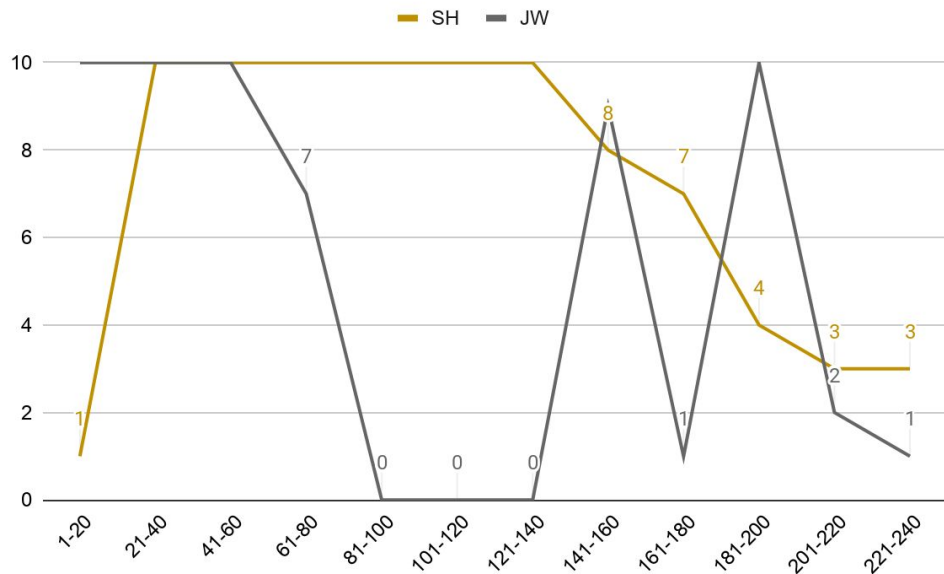
Holmes speaks little at the beginning of the story but his POV starts to dominate towards the climax and the resolution of the story

Watson

Watson's POV dominates at the beginning as well as towards the climax of the story



WATSON'S FRAMING



Holmes

Holmes speaks little but starts to take over the narrative

Watson

Watson's POV dominates at the beginning as well as towards the climax of the story

SH vs JW in 'The Adventure of the Noble Bachelor'

DISCUSSION

- How is the room 'locked'?
 - 'The door' marks the beginning of the mystery.
 - A new character is always introduced immediately after the first occurrence of 'the door'.
 - This new character is the client which means a new case for Sherlock Holmes and Dr Watson.

DISCUSSION

- How is the narrative enclosed?
 - Watson's POV enwrapping the story serving as a frame story:
 - The first TCU and final TCU of all the 10 short stories are all by Dr Watson.
 - Contrasting frequencies of SH and JW in the exposition and rising action of the story:
 - This is when the red herrings (Dr Watson's 'observations' are misleading the readers).
 - Competing frequencies towards the climax and resolution of the story:
 - This is when Holmes corrects Dr Watson's mistakes and explains to his assistant his process of deductive reasoning.
 - Holmes's POV takes over right before the end of the story:
 - The revelation of the truth.

CONCLUSION

- The study has employed quantitative methods to confirm the discourse patterns used in creating suspense.
- It also attempts to show the value of using digital tools in representing and visualising these discourse patterns in literary works.

REFERENCES

- Anthony, L. (2019). AntConc (Version 3.5.8) [Computer Software]. Tokyo, Japan: Waseda University. Available from <http://www.antlab.sci.waseda.ac.jp/>
- Bloom, C. (1988). *Nineteenth-century suspense from Poe to Conan Doyle*. Springer.
- Brewer, W. F., & Lichtenstein, E. H. (1982a). Stories are to entertain: A structural-affect theory of stories. *Journal of Pragmatics*, 6(5-6), 473-486.
- Brewer, W. F., & Lichtenstein, E. H. (1982b). Stories are to entertain: A structural-affect theory of stories. *Center for the Study of Reading Technical Report; no.265*,
- Dove, G. N. (1989). *Suspense in the formula story* Popular Press.
- Clark, U. (2007). Discourse stylistics and detective fiction: A case study. *Literature and stylistics for language learners* (pp. 60-75) Springer.
- Cook, M. (2011). *Narratives of enclosure in detective fiction: The locked room mystery* Springer.
- Gerrig, R. J., & Bernardo, A. B. (1994). Readers as problem-solvers in the experience of suspense. *Poetics*, 22(6), 459-472.

Hartman, G. H., Most, G. W., & Stowe, W. W. (1983). The poetics of murder: Detective fiction and literary theory.

Hoeken, H., & van Vliet, M. (2000). Suspense, curiosity, and surprise: How discourse structure influences the affective and cognitive processing of a story. *Poetics*, 27(4), 277-286.

Hühn, P. (1987). The detective as reader: Narrativity and reading concepts in detective fiction. *Modern Fiction Studies*, 33(3), 451-466.

Levine, C., & Levine, U. C. (2003). *The serious pleasures of suspense: Victorian realism and narrative doubt* University of Virginia Press.

Pearson, N. (2016). *Detective fiction in a postcolonial and transnational world* Routledge.

Prieto-Pablos, J. A. (1998). The paradox of suspense. *Poetics*, 26(2), 99-113.

Segal, E. (2010). Closure in detective fiction. *Poetics Today*, 31(2), 153-215.

Roth, M. (1995). *Foul & fair play: Reading genre in classic detective fiction* University of Georgia Press.

Todorov, T. (1977). The typology of detective fiction. *The Poetics of Prose*, , 42-52.

Vorderer, P., Wulff, H. J., & Friedrichsen, M. (Eds.). (1996). *LEA's communication series. Suspense: Conceptualizations, theoretical analyses, and empirical explorations*. Hillsdale, NJ, US: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, Inc.

Wulff, H. J. (1996). Suspense and the influence of cataphora on viewers' expectations. *Suspense: Conceptualizations, Theoretical Analyses, and Empirical Explorations*,1-17.

THANKS

CREDITS: This presentation template was created by **Slidesgo**, including icons by **Flaticon**, and infographics & images by **Freepik** and illustrations by **Stories**



Please keep this slide for attribution.